Finding the core of a long sentence

Understand it

Long academic sentences are built around a short core: subject + verb + object. Everything else adds detail. When you are lost, cover the commas, brackets and relative clauses and read the core.

In Reading questions, the answer usually depends on the core, but details like dates or limits (only, most) may change the meaning.

The rules

- Every sentence has a core: who (subject) + does what (verb) + what (object). Find it first.
- Everything else is extra: time, place, reason, extra information between commas. You can read it second.
- Long subjects hide the verb: The rapid increase in the number of people who live in cities is a worry. (Core: increase ... is a worry.)
- Cover the parts between commas and read again: the core should still make sense.

All the words and forms you need

Parts that hide the core	prepositional phrases (of, in, with) · relative clauses (which, who) · participle phrases (built in 1900) · appositives (Dr Lee, a biologist,) · brackets
Long subjects	The + noun + of + noun + who ... + VERB
Signals of extra information	commas · dashes · brackets · which · who · that

Where you use it

Reading: Find the core first, then read the details only if the question needs them.

Listening: Listen for the verb and the noun; small words matter less.

Writing: Check that every sentence has a subject and a main verb.

Speaking: Short, clear cores are better than long messy sentences.

More examples

- The development of new medicines, which takes many years, is expensive. (Core: The development is expensive.)
- Researchers at the university, led by Dr Smith, found a link. (Core: Researchers found a link.)
- The fact that bees are disappearing worries farmers. (Core: The fact worries farmers.)
- Many species living in the deep ocean have never been studied. (Core: Many species have never been studied.)

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ Reading every word with the same attention.	✓ Find subject + verb first.
✗ Missing the verb in a long subject.	✓ Look for the first verb after the long noun phrase.
✗ Thinking the first noun is the subject.	✓ The subject may be a long noun group.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Describe a complicated machine or process in short clear sentences.
2. Explain an article you read recently in three simple sentences.
3. What is the main idea of your favorite film?

Writing practice

Find the core of 5 long sentences from your last Reading passage.

Practice

1. Find the core: The old bridge, built in 1890, crosses the river.

2. Find the core: Students who study abroad often improve quickly.

3. Find the verb: The rise in prices caused panic.

4. Find the subject: The growing number of cars in cities is a problem.

5. Cut the extra: Tom, who is my cousin, lives in Paris.

6. Find the core: Most of the farmers in the north grow wheat.

Answers

1. bridge crosses the river
2. Students improve
3. caused
4. The growing number of cars
5. Tom lives in Paris.
6. Most (of the farmers) grow wheat